Convention over configuration means that Rails has sensible defaults for just about every aspect of knitting together your application. Follow the conventions, and you can write a Rails application using less code than a typical JavaScript application uses in JSON configuration. If you need to override the conventions, Rails makes that easy, too.

Developers coming to Rails find something else too. Rails doesn't merely play catch-up with the de facto web standards: it helps define them. And Rails makes it easy for developers to integrate features such as user authentication, modern JavaScript frameworks, RESTful interfaces, and WebSockets into their code because support is built in. (And if you're not familiar with any of these terms, never fear—you'll learn what they mean as you proceed through the book.)

Rails was extracted from a real-world, commercial application. It turns out that the best way to create a framework is to find the central themes in a specific application and then package them in a generic foundation of code. When you're developing your Rails application, you're starting with half of a really good application already in place.

But there's something else to Rails—something that's hard to describe. Somehow, it feels right. Of course, you'll have to take our word for that until you write some Rails applications for yourself (which should be in the next forty-five minutes or so…). That's what this book is all about.